erotiao

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by quags1re

Summary

Mydei would like everyone to know that he can't be the one to awaken Phainon from his cursed sleep with True Love's Kiss, because he is *not* the Deliverer's one True Love.

The entirety of Amphoreus would like to argue otherwise.

Notes

erotiao = to be lovesick (if im reading this translation site right lol)

hello everyone! first of all im so sorry to anyone waiting for a fic of mine to update, i have nothing to say for myself except that im sorry shjfbkhdfhjb

second of all as you can see ive been possessed by yaoi. this myphai shit is serious like i dont ever write oneshots i was fighting back demons to stop myself from making this multichaptered like phew omg

third of all sdjkfsdf. this fic is so silly. when does it take place you ask. shh, i tell you. shh. dont take anything in this fic seriously. lets all pretend we dont see the doomed truck on its way to hit us all. this is a silly time fic turn your brain off everyone

if i made any mistakes i sure did. if i messed up lore whoops. if anyone seems ooc i apologize. also the extra us are cause im canadian. i probably wont correct anything unless its wildly egregious i cant look at this fic anymore i started writing it during mydeis banner and well anaxa is literally next week so uhhh if you can see the part where i def stopped writing and then a weeks later me picked up the draft no you dont

shoutout to beep, my dear friend and constant supporter. thank you for letting me bounce stuff off of you. lets pretend i got this out on time for your birthday

See the end of the work for more notes

It began as an uncharacteristically lazy day for Mydei, which should have been the first sign that something was wrong.

Early morning training went as it usually did, save for the absence of one Deliverer– Mydei had noted his absence and thought nothing of it, as Aglaea had every Chrysos Heir running ragged with little quests to complete– Titankin to slay, villagers to save– all in a day's work. So he trained, shared a meal with his people, and then… Nothing.

There was nothing of grand import to do today. No missions to be sent out on, no meetings to attend, no soldiers that required his training, no scholars that required his knowledge on Kremnoan history… Hell, even the children that enjoyed clinging to his chiton to demand his attention were busy with their studies for the day! And most notably of all, there was no Deliverer to pester him for another match, another outing, *another moment of your time, dear prince. Come now. Won't you indulge me in another bout? Scared to lose?*

Mydei shakes his head to physically dislodge the memory. How could he spend his free time thinking of the Deliverer? He already *spent* all of his free time with the man. Instead, he should use the time to do literally anything else– anything would be more productive than wondering how his mission is going, how long it would take him to return to Okhema, why the man hadn't even told Mydei he was leaving when he was certain that they'd made a pact to inform the other if they were leaving on quests, just in case the other required assistance, or in case the mission went south–

He's doing it again. Mydei runs a frustrated hand through his hair. Perhaps he should partake in some fare from the diner he often frequents– *No,* he and Phainon regularly share meals there, and the servers will be sure to ask where the man is. Alright, then… He should visit Marmoreal Market and peruse the wares– *No,* he'd share the exact same problem as with the diner! Every vendor would be asking after Phainon! They loved to spoil that man with deals and samples…

Urgh. How frustrating that a single man could be so loud and occupy so much space even in his absence!

Mydei decides to just retreat to his chambers and have a nice nap. He hasn't done so in so very long, and there was no way that the Deliverer could torment him even in his dreams, right? Right.

So he settles down onto his cushions and throws an arm over his eyes in a futile attempt to keep Okhema's unending day from disrupting his slumber. Oddly enough, he falls asleep quite easily– and has a strange dream about… punching someone in the face? While in a kitchen?

“Mydei!”

Mydei tosses and turns. No, the face of the person he's punched is blurry, and he'd like to see it. Besides, he hasn't slept so well in so long. If he squints, maybe he can make out fluffy hair…

“Hey! Get up!”

Blue eyes, a fair complexion…

“Hellooooo~? Crown prince! Help! There's a damsel in need of rescuing!”

Mydei sits up, bleary from sleep. Was that the Deliverer that he punched? *In his dreams as well?* Could the Deliverer stop running through his mind, or what? Were the two of them simply fated to encounter one another even in dreams? Perhaps Mydei should get another hobby that wouldn't involve that man showing up and asserting himself.

…No, knowing Phainon, it would be impossible. When Mydei cooks, he appears. When Mydei bathes, he appears. Phainon, Phainon, Phainon!

“Mrgh,” he grumbles.

“Woah, that worked,” a voice exclaims. It's the one of the Trailblazers, Caelus, and his fluffy pink squirrel. “You're just missing a white horse and a cool sword, oh crown prince.”

“...What?”

“Nothing, really.” Caelus says, smiling wide. “Don't ask questions. Come with us! This is a kidnapping!”

The young man takes Mydei by the wrist and starts running out of the room. And just when Mydei finally gains enough awareness to realize that he may truly be in the process of being kidnapped, Caelus has dragged him to their destination, the… Square in front of Marmoreal Palace?

There's a small crowd gathered, forming a circle around someone that he can't quite make out, on account of the rabble. But he can spot the Ladies Tribios, Castorice and Hyacine, and that other Trailblazer, Dan Heng, too… Plus a handful of others pretending that they aren't watching the ongoing commotion.

“Agy and Naxy shall be here shortly,” Mydei hears Tribbie say. “They're busy bickering over the origins of this curse. Once they're done gazing into each other's eyes like they don't want to make out, they'll be here! They won't want to miss this. And Little Gray is bringing De, of course…”

Curse?

Caelus drags him to the center of the crowd, where someone has haphazardly dragged over a daybed. A daybed that the Deliverer has passed out on.

“Phainon?” Mydei hears himself blurt. A hush falls over the crowd as Mydei frees himself from Caelus’ grasp and hurries to the Deliverer’s side. “What happened?!”

He checks for breathing. Steady. And then a pulse. Slow, but even steadier. No visible wounds, either. The man simply looks to be asleep, but would there be a crowd if he was simply sleeping? Mydei looks to the triplets for an answer, and then Hyacine as well.

Oddly enough, the crowd is smothering giggles. Mydei can feel his face drop. “Is the Deliverer attempting to prank me again?” The prince asks, voice even.

“No,” Dan Heng says.

“It’s *happening*,” Caelus says, at the same time. He sounds way too pleased. Is that a camera in his hands?

Castorice folds her hands in front of her. “No, Lord Mydei. We have need of your assistance. You see…”

She trails off, eyes darting to the side. In fact, now that Mydei's noticing it, everyone's… Fidgeting. Odd. But if it wasn't a prank, then what was it?

“Snowy’s been cursed and he won't wake up!” Tribbie declares, waving her arms around. “We need your help, De!”

Mydei's heart sputters against the cage of his chest. “What? Explain!”

The long and short of it is this; the Deliverer had protected some fool from activating some long-dormant trap to prove his thesis by… allowing himself to be hit by its effects instead. Yes. How very like the Deliverer to suffer the consequences of his hero complex. The details are convoluted, but long story short, as the Lady Tribbie explains, it was a trap devised by Mnestia and *Zagreus*, of all the possible cursed combinations. Confirmed by Aglaea, the professor Anaxa, and Cipher, who was busy destroying what remained of the aforementioned trap, there was nothing that they could do but drag Phainon's body back to Okhema and wait for the cure.

Mydei cannot possibly begin to understand how the two Titans decided to conspire like that. He supposes he didn't need to understand. He just needed to fix this.

“Shall I go and destroy the remnants of the trap with Lady Cipher?” Mydei asks, already adjusting his gauntlets in preparation for a long and arduous battle. Who knows what trials Mnestia and Zagreus would make one undergo in order to counter one of their curses? “Slay a monster? Retrieve ancient texts to find the cure? Point me the way, Lady Tribbie. We need to do what we can to get this fool back on his feet.”

Tribbie, Trianne, and Trinnon all make Xs simultaneously with their arms. “It's alright, De!” Tribbie says, oddly bright for someone discussing a curse. “We already know how to cure Snowy.”

Mydei frowns. “Should I seek out an ingredient, or potion, then…?” He asks, genuinely confused at all the smiles he's getting. Hyacine is giggling into her hand. Caelus isn't even bothering to hide his laughter, even when Dan Heng tries to shush him. Hells, even Castorice looks far too amused for the situation at hand. “What is it? What does he need?”

“We have the cure,” Trinnon reiterates, voice as soft as ever.

“Then why hasn't anyone used it?” Mydei demands, his chest growing hot with offense. While everyone was laughing, Phainon was–

“The cure is…” Tribbie pauses for dramatic effect. “True Love's kiss!”

…Huh?

Was Mydei still half-asleep? Did she just say…

True Love's kiss?

“That's why we haven't been able to wake him yet!” Trianne adds. “Because we were waiting for his one True Love to come to the rescue!”

Indignation quickly fades away to confusion. “...Are you making fun of me?” Mydei wonders, feeling lost.

“Nuh-uh!” The triplets declare as one. Mydei looks to the others for help. They all shrug at him, barely fighting off their smiles.

“True Love's kiss isn't a real thing,” Mydei tries, still in disbelief that this isn't a prank. “It's a concept in stories for children. Pure fiction.”

“Nuh uh,” Trianne denies. “Agy confirmed that True Love's kiss is a real thing.”

“And is the Lady Aglaea the leading expert on the matter?” Mydei asks.

Everyone looks at him strangely. It's enough to fluster him. “Who else if not Agy?” Tribbie counters. You know what? Fair enough. “Besides, we have actual documented records on this sorta thing. Married couples and friends and such being hit by this curse. You see?”

Mydei did not, in fact, see.

“It's not the strangest thing that I've seen in my time as a Trailblazer,” Caelus adds. Dan Heng nods along. Wasn't he Caelus’ only scrap of self control and reason? Help him out, please. “In fact, it's not even the strangest thing I've seen in Okhema, dude.”

That wasn't really reassuring. Mydei brushes hair away from Phainon's face and takes a deep breath to regain his composure. “So? I assume you all know who his True Love is, since you're all quite calm. Are we waiting on them?”

He ignores the way that his chest clenches at the thought of the Deliverer’s fated love. As long as the man wakes up, Mydei should feel relieved, so what were these complex emotions muddling his mind?

“Nope! They're already here!” Tribbie points somewhere in Mydei's general direction. Confused, he turns around. No one is there. He turns back around and spots a sea of smug faces. It suddenly hits him, what everyone seems to think–

“Me!?” Mydei booms, pointing at himself.

“You,” Trinnon confirms, bobbing her head.

“Me, the Deliverer’s one True Love?!” Mydei demands. “How– How can that be?”

For some reason, it's the crowd's turn to give him a confused look. “Well, who else could it be?” Hyacine asks. “There's no one else but you.”

“But I– *Huh?!*” Hello? What in the world?

“You gotta smooch him! A little kiss! You know? Should be easy! Don't you guys do it all the time?”

“No?!?” Mydei sputters. “The two of us, we… We aren't even like that?!”

Confused mumbles start to build in the crowd. Mydei can even hear the congregation in the distance start going *what?!* and *huh?!* at each other when *he's* the one meant to be going what and huh, excuse you.

“If you're not *like that*, then why was I feeling like a third wheel for that entire outing we had?” Caelus demands, looking aghast.

“The entirety of Okhema feels like a third wheel whenever the two of you are out and about!” Mydei hears someone yell in the distance. He's going to ignore that for the sake of his sanity.

“What about the betting pool of when you two will get married?!” He also hears from afar. He'll ignore that, too. And how he hears a whole slew of people shush whoever spoke.

Castorice actually has a hand over her mouth. “I genuinely believed that the two of you were lovers this whole time,” she adds, voice soft.

Lovers?!

“We're not lovers?” It comes out as a question, for what reason.

“*Then what the hell were we all subjected to?!*” Mydei hears, again, from a distance.

“Still, there's no one else but you for Snowy, De,” Tribbie says, hands on her hips. “Can you honestly think of anyone else with a closer bond with him than you?”

Mydei opens his mouth… And then closes it.

Well! Well!!! Even if True Love's kiss was a thing, an actual curse-breaking thing, what the hell did that have to do with him and the Deliverer? Sure, their bond was… Indescribable, but it wasn't, like, *that!*

“And according to Agy, it must be on the lips! Otherwise it won't work!”

Wh–

Mydei swears that he hears something explode in the distance. Or maybe that's just his brain.

Everyone is now looking at him with expectant eyes. Somehow, even though Phainon is literally unconscious and sprawled out on the daybed, Mydei can somehow feel his sparkly gaze drilling holes through his face. Urgh.

How could Mydei make them *see* the truth of this matter?

“I don't think that he thinks that we're like that,” Mydei says.

“Don't be shy,” Caelus grins, catlike. He makes little kissy sounds that Dan Heng valiantly attempts to smother with his hands. Mydei is briefly grateful to the man. Though his attempts were clearly in vain, Mydei appreciated the effort. “Just think of it like first aid. CPR. Trust my expertise.”

“What expertise?” Dan Heng mumbles.

“I'm not shy!” Mydei counters. He takes a deep breath to regain his composure. “It's only– You're wrong! All of you! How could you collectively decide– I– How could I possibly be the Deliverer’s True Love? We bicker–”

“Like a married couple,” Tribbie offers.

“–and we come to blows more often than not–”

“I thought that that's just how the two of you flirt?” Hyacine adds, sounding genuinely confused.

“*–I don't even think he likes men?!*” Mydei blurts, not knowing why everyone is looking at him like *he's* the crazy one.

“Phainon's Mydei-sexual,” Caelus says, nodding at nothing and no one in particular. What. “I think it's cute. Have you ever seen a more fixated man?”

It sounds like a rhetorical question, so Mydei will simply not answer. And pretend to not have heard. He looks to the others for help.

Castorice looks like she wants to put a gentle hand on his shoulder. Instead, she tilts her head to one side. “It's okay to be embarrassed about kissing him,” she says, trying for sympathetic. It falls flat. Like her voice.

“*I'M NOT EMBARRASSED.*”

“We can turn around! And shut our eyes! If it makes you feel better!” Trianne blurts. She covers her eyes with her hands. This action is immediately negated by her peeking through her fingers.

Mydei shuts his eyes and takes a deep, grounding breath. “Okay. Why does everyone think that I'm the Deliverer’s one True Love? I need proof, or I am heading out on a quest to find a different cure.”

Everyone in the general vicinity exchanges glances. Mydei is seriously going to kick Phainon's ass when he wakes up, for making him go through this. “Well?”

Hyacine claps her hands together to draw his attention. “If you want examples, then what about that time that Phainon was testing that healing draught, and became all loopy?”

Oh, no. He immediately knows what she's getting at. “The Deliverer was on drugs,” Mydei instinctively protests.

“Wait, what? Spill?” Caelus blurts, at the exact same time. The two of them lock eyes, one incredibly embarrassed and the other hungry for gossip.

Hyacine's eyes practically sparkle at the chance to tell her story. “Well… This took place a few months ago, when many of our healers left the city to go support a distant village with an outbreak of Titankin. The healers that

remained, like myself, decided to experiment with new healing draughts to make up for the loss in labour…”

Mydei runs a hand down his face at the memory of that day, knowing full well that everyone would take it out of context. The context being the Deliverer being not in his right mind.

Kephale, rescue him from this plight…!

.

While on his way to find the Deliverer and give him a tongue lashing for being so extraordinarily tardy to their meeting, Mydei finds Lady Hyacine awkwardly pacing the halls and fidgeting with her hair. Huh. And when they lock eyes, she yelps and covers her face with her hands, guilt seeping through every bit of her actions. She's so incredibly suspicious-looking that Mydei immediately begins to suspect that she's somehow involved with the Deliverer’s absence.

He crosses the hall to greet her and she shrinks down. Like that would stop him from seeing her.

“Have you seen the Deliverer around?” Mydei asks, folding his arms across his chest. “He promised to meet me for a meal, but he's late.”

Hyacine freezes in place, and then winces. “I'm sorry! He told me that he had plans with you, but we didn't expect our little experiment to take longer than an hour.” She gestures for him to follow, her gait wobbly. “I should have gone to tell you immediately, but I was sort of hoping that he'd just be fine before I found you.”

He shakes his head, dismissing her worries. “Experiment?” Mydei asks, already deciding not to blame her. He's sure that Phainon refused to acknowledge his limits, *again*, and ended up in some sticky situation. Again.

“As you know, not all of Okhema's healers are healers in the way that I am,” Hyacine explains, leading Mydei through a set of doors. “Some rely

on potions, and draughts, and other such items. Due to the surge of Titankin in the west, many of our healers have been sent to meet the wounded halfway, so we've been stocking up on healing items in their absence. And, you know, while we're at it, we decided to try new formulas to see what'd work."

Mydei frowns. "Let me guess. The Deliverer was testing one of these new formulas?"

"Yes! But he's not injured, or in any pain, just… You'll see," she says, looking flustered. "The formula, it's meant to take away pain, make it so the patient feels nothing at all so our healers can work their magic without any additional duress. But it has, well, um. It has unforeseen side effects! Temporary loss of memory, of inhibitions… It's all temporary, I swear!"

Mydei shoots her an alarmed look. "It wears off quick!" Hyacine blurts, throwing up her hands. "Thirty minutes minimum, a day, max. Phainon thought he'd be one of the thirty minute men. He was, um, not correct."

The healer guides him to one of the sickrooms. The beds are divided by thick curtains, and Hyacine pulls aside the closest one to reveal the Deliverer, who doesn't even look up at their sudden arrival.

"Be gentle with him," Hyacine says. Mydei barely hears her. He's too distracted by the dazed look on Phainon's face. The Deliverer genuinely looks like there are stars spinning around his head, eyes foggy and unfocused. "His memory isn't stable. It'll return within the day, but he didn't recall my name. I'm not sure that he'll know yours. Some people can hardly remember their own name, others only lose a few memories. It all depends on the person."

"Oh, he'll know my name," Mydei says, lip curling. "He has no choice." Hyacine huffs, the sound more amused than anything else.

"If you're going to scold him, then scold him when he has all his memories in order," Hyacine urges. "This Phainon has no idea where he is, really. He'll have no idea that he even missed your date."

Date?

Before he can correct her, Phainon finally turns to Mydei. They lock eyes.

It's… Strange. Usually, Phainon's gaze is a whole lot more intense. Keen. His eyes alone demand a challenge, like he's asking– no, demanding that Mydei gazes back with the same amount of passion. *Look at me, look at me, look at me,* the Deliverer would demand, somehow, with his eyes alone. *Don't look away.*

The current Phainon looks incredibly silly in comparison. Like some happy-go-lucky chimera who knows nothing but treats and cuddles.

“Oh, you're…”

Mydei ignores his languid words. “Deliverer. Do you have anything to say for yourself?” In the background, he hears Hyacine groan playfully.

Phainon does not have anything to say for himself on account of him immediately bursting into tears.

Naturally, Mydei panics at the unfamiliar sight. Tears?! From Phainon, of all people?! The man who would rather perish than show the citizens any sort of weakness?! Who laughs off battle wounds and injuries so people don't worry for him?!

Mydei's chest begins to ache. Strangely enough, every tear feels akin to a blade through his chest.

“Why are you crying?” The prince demands, truly at a loss for what to do. He leans forward and wipes away his tears with a gentle thumb. “Lady Hyacine! Something is wrong!”

Before Hyacine can even think to step in, Phainon speaks.

“You're so beautiful and I *don't know your name,*” Phainon sobs. Mydei freezes. “Waaah!”

Hyacine snorts and slaps a hand over her mouth at the sound. “Loss of inhibitions,” she explains. “I did say it.”

She did, but Mydei didn't exactly expect the Deliverer to act like this. “Don't cry,” Mydei says, because what else can he say. “Your tears are unnecessary. There is nothing to cry about, Deliverer…”

“Who are you? Why do I feel this way?” Phainon continues to weep, like he hasn't heard. “You're… You're so everything.”

That sentence didn't even make sense.

Mydei can't look away from the tears streaming down Phainon's face. Whenever he brushes them away, the man only seems to get more and more weepy.

“I am called Mydeimos,” Mydei says, feeling as though someone's put a spell on him. Like he'd do anything at all to stop Phainon from shedding tears.

“Mydeimos,” Phainon croons, sinking into the sheets. He's stopped crying, now. “Mydeimos, Mydeimos, Mydeimos. Even your name contains multitudes. Multitudes of beauty. Like your face and body.”

What the hell did that even mean. Mydei turns to Hyacine. “Are you sure that he doesn't have any head trauma? Maybe he was hiding an injury,” he suggests, voice a tad shrill.

“There's no head trauma,” Hyacine says, giggling. Well, Mydei's glad that someone is having fun in this situation.

“There is head trauma!” Phainon blurts.

“Right,” Mydei says, sitting on the side of the mattress.

“No, really,” Phainon continues, leaning forward. “When I saw you, the world started spinning.” Okay, was that a compliment or an insult?

“Uh huh,” Mydei says, suddenly amused himself. “And what do you want me to do about that?”

“I think that if I bury my face in your chest I'll be allllll better,” Phainon says, starry-eyed.

Ha.

Mydei leans forward, steals the pillow from behind Phainon's back, and attempts to smother the Deliverer with it.

“I'll bury you in *something,* you HKS–!”

“WAAAIT!” Hyacine yelps, leaping forward to grab the pillow. Mydei is undeterred, but Phainon is slippery, and wriggles around on the mattress like a worm. “He doesn't mean it! Lord Mydei, please, he's delusional!”

“I mean it,” Phainon gasps, taking huge gulps of air when he can. “I've never meant anything more…!”

“Oh *yeah?!*” Mydei bellows, face aflame. He punctuates every word with a slap of the pillow. Feathers fly everywhere. “I'm going to– Grant your wish– And slay you– Right here!”

“I'd let you slay me,” Phainon continues, tone still dreamy and utterly unaffected by the assault via pillow. “If you promise to hold me tight the whole time. To your chest. If you're feeling nice. I hope you are. Are you?”

Mydei's face burns with the force of his embarrassment. He brings down the pillow again, and somehow, it explodes.

Sudden silence fills the room, and Mydei is suddenly aware that everyone is staring. Curtains are pulled to the side, people are peeking around the doors, and Hyacine looks incredibly unimpressed with him. Whoops.

So Hyacine drags him outside of the room and scolds him for a bit. Says that while it's perfectly understandable to be flustered by his words, that he shouldn't disturb the other patients, as most of them truly are recovering from an ailment.

“Still, I understand your reaction, Lord Mydei. If you're really uncomfortable with him right now, you should make yourself scarce. You can absolutely make him pay for his inappropriate words. …After he recovers,” Hyacine says, contrite. “Please don't actually fight in the sickbay.”

Mydei makes a face. “...It's fine if it's the Deliverer saying these things. If it were anyone else, I would have already dragged them out for a duel over my honour.”

The prince knows that the Deliverer doesn't mean anything by it. And Mydei's well aware that Phainon’s incredibly loopy. He wouldn't punish the man too much for his words when he's so clearly not himself– he wouldn't have gone for the pillow otherwise.

“I can tolerate his nonsense,” he adds. “I already do, even when he's not deluded. Don't fret.” Just the other day Phainon asked him if they would still be rivals if he was a worm, which… What?

“...Oh?” Hyacine says. Her expression clears up. “Oh…! Oh! I completely understand. Congratulations! I'm genuinely happy for you both!”

Mydei would like to know what she's understood, because personally, he's confused. But before he can ask, she barrels on.

“Please indulge Phainon as much as you can, then,” Hyacine implores, a smile on her face. “Some patients have had unpleasant reactions when told that what they currently believe is incorrect. Their confusion, mixed with their loss of memory and lack of inhibition resulted in some minor, um, freakouts. Physical ones. We wouldn't want a Chrysos Heir to do the same, especially in the sickbay.”

Right, Mydei can imagine the chaos now. He nods. “Understood.”

“I should go check on the other patients,” Hyacine says, hands on her hips. “I'll leave him in your hands. Congratulations again!”

She quite literally skips back into the room before Mydei can ask what she's congratulating him for. Deciding to just ignore it, Mydei returns to the room as well, pulls back the curtain, and finds Phainon struggling to remain upright against the wall.

“HKS,” Mydei scolds, immediately putting his arms around him, “what do you think you're doing? You're not supposed to leave your bed when you're feeble. Sit back down.”

Phainon immediately attempts to sit on the floor at the command, nearly bringing Mydei down with him. The prince curses. “On the bed, you fool! I didn't say right here!”

“But you told me to sit,” Phainon whines, looking up at him with watery blue eyes. Still, he allows Mydei to drag him back to his bed and tuck him under the blanket with minimal complaints.

“Where were you even planning to go?” Mydei asks, raising an eyebrow.

“I wanted to find you,” Phainon says. He still sounds like he's talking through a dream. “You left. Why would I stay?”

Mydei shakes his head. “Focus on recovering, HKS. Don't do anything foolish.”

“I'm nooot HKS. That's not my name,” Phainon pouts. “I'm Phainon. That's me. Can you say my name? Pleaseee? Please, Mydeimos?”

Mydei can't help but be amused. “Can't you be both?”

Phainon stares at him, clearly processing the information. “I can be both,” he finally allows. “If you want me to be both. I can be HKS Phainon. That's my name now.”

Mydei grins.

“What are we to one another?” Phainon asks, an expectant look on his face. “Looking at you is like, wow. Wow.”

That was a loaded question. It was already difficult to explain their relationship to anyone, even when Phainon wasn't addled. Friends? Colleagues? Neither of those sounded right. Perhaps comrades?

“Rivals,” Mydei decides. “And partners.”

“*Partners?!*” Phainon repeats, voice cracking. “Oh wow. How'd I do that? Go me.”

He then pats himself on the back. Mydei feels like he's missing something crucial, but decides not to press. After all, the Deliverer was not in his right mind.

“You look like you're running a fever,” Mydei says instead, eyeing Phainon's red face. “I think you should sleep. Perhaps when you wake, the draught will have worn off, and then I can yell at you without feeling guilty.”

“I don't wanna sleep,” Phainon complains, sounding several years younger. “I want to bury my face in your chest because we're rival-partners.”

Instinctively, Mydei opens his mouth to chide the man–

–Then Mydei is reminded about what Hyacine said about indulging him, to not further confuse the patient.

“...If you come to your senses soon, then *maybe*.” Mydei allows, not looking at him.

Silence.

Incredibly prolonged silence.

Incredibly prolonged, charged silence.

Mydei finally turns to Phainon, confused. No comment on his chest or about how wow he finds him–?

Miracle of miracles, when Mydei locks eyes with the Deliverer, he looks– *Aware?* Properly lucid? How in the world did he recover so fast? Was that even normal? Mydei had truly believed that it would take longer than that!

“I missed our meeting,” Phainon says, guiltily. His gaze is as clear as ever, a sign that he's back to normal. Which is a relief, but also– How? “Didn't I.”

Mydei realizes that it doesn't truly matter, so long as the Deliverer is hale and whole. Now he can begin to scold him with no remorse.

.

“...See? How could I not think that you two were together?” Hyacine says, finishing her story. Her audience– because their little ensemble of people has become an audience, now– all clap like it was a proper theatrical performance.

“Drugs,” Mydei defends, his arms crossing and uncrossing.

“But I heard you call each other partners!” Hyacine defends.

“Partners doesn't necessarily mean lovers!” Mydei shoots back, wondering why he's getting up in arms about this. “I've heard the Deliverer call the Trailblazer his partner! Are they romantically involved?”

“Woah, don't bring me into this,” Caelus says, hand to his chest. “You *just* said partners doesn't necessarily mean lovers! Ours is a strictly platonic bond–”

“You see–”

“–Unlike theirs!”

Mydei throws up his hands. Clearly he wasn't getting anywhere with this argument.

“Are we just ignoring the part of the story where Phainon said, multiple times, that he wants to be buried in the crown prince's chest?” Dan Heng

mutters. Well, Mydei didn't know about the rest of them, but *he* was going to ignore that part.

Castorice takes a step forward. “Lord Mydei, I also have a story that I'd like to share,” she says. “One that may convince you to admit to your shared affections.”

Mydei blinks. Shared? Wait. Castorice, of all people, sharing a story about him and the Deliverer?

She lifts a finger. “The arm wrestling competition,” Castorice begins, voice soft. A chorus of *ooooooooohs* fill the air. Mydei wants to join them, but just to groan. “Lord Mydei, don't you recall?”

“...I do.”

“Do you deny any and all romantic implications of that day?” She prods.

“Implications? Don't you mean assumptions?” Mydei asks. Castorice shakes her head.

“So you deny it… Very well. Everyone, please hear me out. I have long believed that Lord Mydei and Lord Phainon have been romantically involved, and the events of that day have only strengthened those beliefs…”

Oh boy.

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At mealtime, Phainon waves a flyer beneath Mydei's nose.

“Join this with me,” he says, not explaining a thing or even pausing to greet him properly. What happened to hello? Good day? Mydei snatches the flyer out of his hands before he sneezes.

ARM WRESTLING COMPETITION!!!!!! it reads, with an egregious amount of exclamation points. **CASH PRIZES INCLUDED!!! AND BRAGGING RIGHTS!!!!!!**

Mydei lowers the flyer to see the Deliverer batting his eyes at him. Must they? Of course, Mydei would never back down from a bout with Phainon, but weren't two Chrysos Heirs joining a civilian competition a bit too much?

“Are you lacking in funds, Deliverer?” Mydei simpers, a faux-sympathetic note to his words. “Perhaps you should stop finding creative new ways to pay the bill before we even step into the diner, then.”

The prince had caught the man paying Kyros for their meal *hours* before their reservation multiple times. The Deliverer had once even paid a group of children to hold Mydei down at the table so he could go pay before Mydei could even glance at the bill. Silly.

“Why, Mydei! If I didn't know better, I'd say that you were afraid of losing!” Mydei's eye twitches. He can't let that stand.

“Afraid of losing?” Mydei repeats, not realizing that he's on his feet. “To who? You? Good thing that you *do* know better.”

Phainon braces a hand on the table, leaning all up in Mydei's face. If he wanted him to back down, then ha! Fat chance of that! “Oh, dear prince! How could I possibly know any better when all I hear is talk and no action?”

Their foreheads are touching, now. And Phainon's eyes are so very blue. “I'll show you action, Deliverer.”

“Oh? Bet you won't. Bet you're going to bow out with some grandiose excuse about “letting others win.” But sure, if it makes you feel better…”

They're sharing breaths, at this point. “*Nothing* would make me feel better than crushing you,” Mydei murmurs. He watches Phainon's eyes flicker down, and–

“Before you lunge at each other, need I remind you that others are attempting to tuck into their meals?”

Mydei and Phainon look up. Aglaea is there, just a few seats down, and dabbing at her mouth with a napkin. In fact, all of the Heirs have stopped eating to stare at them. Wordlessly, Mydei and Phainon decide to sit.

“Were they going to smooch?” A tiny, childlike voice asks.

“Shh, they can hear you!” Phainon coughs. Mydei drags a hand down his face.

So anyway, they end up joining the competition.

It's amassed quite the crowd. More than Mydei expected, actually. But perhaps that's Phainon's fault– their little scene at mealtime the other day had been passed around via Verax Leo and by word of mouth, and any event with multiple Chrysos Heirs in attendance would gain a following.

Even Castorice is here. Mydei does a double take. Phainon does a *triple take.*

“Lady Castorice,” Phainon gasps. “What a surprise. I didn't expect you to be here. This doesn't seem like your scene– not that you can't join! It's just– don't you normally avoid these events?”

She gives them an embarrassed look. As embarrassed as Castorice *can* be, at least.

“I'm a competitor,” she says, eyes on the floor. Mydei has the sudden realization that she will sweep the floor with her opponents, and that her only possible competition was… Himself? “Excuse me.”

She scurries away.

“Ah, she's so going to win,” Phainon laughs, putting a hand on Mydei's back to navigate through the crowd. “But there's no reason that we can't still bet on our own match, yeah?”

Mydei huffs. He knew this was coming.

“What are the stakes?” The prince asks. The Deliverer puffs out his chest, clearly having already prepared an answer.

“If I win, you'll be at my mercy for an entire day,” Phainon declares, looking oddly proud of himself for no reason. “You'll do whatever I say.”

“Within reason?”

“Of course,” Phainon says, hand to his chest. “I wouldn't dare to embarrass the crown prince. I only want his time. Uninterrupted time, where he doesn't run off to go coax children who want to play with him, or get stolen by soldiers who want him to train with them.”

Huh?

Now why was he speaking like Mydei wasn't standing right there? And besides…

“So you only want me to spend a whole day with you?” Mydei confirms, slightly confused. This was hardly worth a wager.

“Without any distractions,” the Deliverer nods. “Just you and me.”

“That's how we spend our free time regardless,” Mydei says, unimpressed. Even he will admit that they're attached by the hip– it's simply the way of things. The citizens of Okhema are too intimidated by their titles of Chrysos Heir and Crown Prince to become familiar with them, and so the pair can only confide in one another.

Besides, despite how infuriating the Deliverer can be at times, he has proven himself to be a worthy companion, and trustworthy enough to watch Mydei's back. Of course they would spend what little free time they had together.

“No way!” Phainon shakes his head. “Last time that we spent time together, you ran off!”

Did he? They spend so much time with each other, Mydei can hardly recall. “If I had to cut our meeting short, then it was for important matters,” he

says.

“*And* the time before that there was Chartonus, and the time before that too with those chimeras from the Garden of Life,” Phainon continues, completely ignoring him. “*Chimeras!* Over me!”

“They requested my aid,” Mydei says, flatly.

“You can't even understand them!”

“Says who?”

“T-that's besides the point! Your day will be mine, Mydeimos!” Phainon declares, pointing a finger at him for some reason.

“Why are you talking like you've already won?”

“I'll even hold onto your hand the whole time so you don't escape,” he continues, like that isn't a ridiculous thing to say.

“You can't possibly want to hold my hand for an entire day,” Mydei says, flat.

Phainon lifts his chin. “Wanna bet?”

What a ridiculous man.

“Fine then. If I win, you'll be at *my* mercy,” he drawls, and then stomps off.

“For a day, right?!” Phainon calls at his back. “Right?!”

Of course, the prince ignores him.

Mydei breezes through the preliminaries and the quarter finals without breaking a sweat. Most of his opponents groan and lament their lack of luck when they see who they're matched up against, but the Kremnoans that do face him try to match his might as best they can.

By the time he reaches the semi-finals, an even greater crowd has gathered. Mydei watches money exchange hands– of course the match between Chrysos Heirs would draw this much attention. Still. Isn't their audience a bit too excited? Were there really people holding up banners with their faces on it? Where did they even get those? Who was making them? Why was there even a market for such a thing in the first place?

“So you finally made it here,” Phainon declares, like this wasn't the obvious outcome for both of them. “I hope you're not too tired from your matches. I would hate for you to use exhaustion as an excuse to lose.”

Mydei scoffs. Why was the Deliverer acting like the orator? “I hope you remember these words when I crush you,” he says, taking his place in front of Phainon at the table.

“I've already planned out our day,” Phainon says, like he hasn't heard. He props his elbow up on the table. “Don't be surprised when you actually enjoy this loss. Maybe you'll even take to losing!”

Losing? Him?

“Ha! You've become quite arrogant. Fine then. You'll learn your place once you're at my mercy!”

“My place? Forget about my place, you should learn where yours is!”

“Oh?”

“When I have you submit to me you'll know…” Phainon trails off for dramatic effect. “Your place is beneath me!”

Pompous. For some reason, this makes the crowd go wild. He can't let this stand.

Mydei bares his teeth. “Beneath you? Don't kid yourself, Deliverer. When it comes to you, know that I'm *always* on top!”

“KYAAAAAAAA!”

The crowd sure loved their trash talk. Before Phainon can retort, the event's orator approaches them, looking incredibly unsure of themselves.

“Excuse me, your Highness, Lord Phainon… I don't mean to interrupt your, ah, banter, but may I announce the start of the round…?”

Mydei feels a sudden stab of pity for the orator just doing their job. Phainon must feel the same, because he coughs awkwardly.

“Sorry, you can count us down now…”

Both Chrysos Heirs get into position, grasping each other's hand. Phainon grins. “My hand is bigger than yours,” he brags.

“It's not,” Mydei denies. Though, he will admit that their hands were similar in size. Perhaps they should compare them properly later. “You only think yours is bigger than it is because I'm not wearing my gauntlets, HKS.”

“What do your gauntlets have to do with anything? I'm just telling it like it is,” Phainon says. “And your hands are like a furnace. Softer than I thought, too.”

Mydei raises a brow. “You've thought about my hands?”

Suddenly, Phainon finds the ground to be fascinating. “Well! You always keep them covered, and all! I thought you were born with them on, since you even wear them in the baths! Aren't you worried about rust?”

The prince chuckles.

“Don't laugh at me, Mydei!” Phainon whines. His face is flushed. “I'm serious!”

Though the Deliverer complains, he still hasn't let go of Mydei's hand. The prince takes the time to examine their hands together.

“Well, your hands are *freezing*,” Mydei comments, deciding to have mercy by dropping the comment on his gauntlets. After all, he was about to experience a most tragic loss. “And your fingers are quite slender. You may

want to invest in some protection for them– your hands do important work, after all."

"My goodness, Mydei!" Phainon coos, mockery evident in every syllable. "Is that worry I hear? For *me?*"

"Yes," Mydei nods, hand tight around Phainon's own.

"Hgnfh?!"

"Knowing you, your hands will get all sweaty on some important mission and your claymore will slip right out of your hands," Mydei continues. Phainon's face does something funny. "And you'll manage to impale yourself upon your own blade trying to rescue a chimera or something equally ridiculous."

"I'm not taking this from you, Mister Saviour Complex!"

"*Me?!* Mister Saviour Complex?! Have you looked in a mirror recently, Deliverer?! On your last mission, didn't you let yourself get stabbed just so that–"

The orator clears their throat and both men shut their mouths with a *hmph!*

"Okaaaay, we're going to ignore that!" The orator announces. "Your Highness, are you ready?"

"I have been ready," Mydei replies.

"And you, Lord Phainon?"

Phainon makes a show of rolling his shoulders. "Born ready."

The orator counts them down from ten for dramatic effect, lifts a hand… And throws it down. "BEGIN!"

"Gnh!"

"Heup!"

Mydei and Phainon have always been equally matched in most anything, and arm wrestling matches are no different. Already Mydei can feel his biceps straining with the effort to keep Phainon at bay– though the Deliverer’s clothes make him look more slender, Mydei knows full well that they hide a build similar to his own.

It doesn't help that their audience is becoming feverishly excited. Mydei can't afford any distractions. Give the Deliverer an inch, and it'd be over…!

“CRUSH HIM, YOUR HIGHNESS!”

“DON'T LOSE! LORD PHAINON!!! TOPPLE HIM! DOMINATE HIM!!!”

…Some of their cheers were more suspect than others. Mydei tries to ignore the shouts and focuses on the feeling of Phainon's hand in his.

While the other matches were over in a matter of seconds, theirs is not. Both Mydei and Phainon grasp the table with their free hand for some fleeting purchase, grunting all the while.

“KYAAAA! YOUR HIGHNESS! SHOW THAT MAN WHO TOPS!”

“LORD PHAINON! MAKE HIM SUBMIT AND I'LL BUY A ROUND FOR EVERYONE HERE TONIGHT!”

“You– heard that man,” Phainon grunts, voice straining with the efforts of their match. “You'll get a drink if you just give up now…! Think of your precious pomegranate juice and milk…!”

Mydei squeezes his hand even tighter and relishes in the groan that slips through the Deliverer’s lips. “Having to rely on the generosity of others– to secure a victory…? You've changed, Deliverer!”

Phainon laughs, squeezing right back. Mydei tries not to show the wince on his face, but he's clearly failed judging by the newly added sparkle to Phainon's eyes.

“Feeling the heat, my prince? Are you– getting nervous? Do I make you *nervous*, Mydeimos?” Phainon teases. Mydei watches a drop of sweat roll down the Deliverer’s brow and swallows. His throat is dry.

“...Hardly!”

Mydei can't let this infuriating man claim victory!

If the Deliverer wanted to spend time with him so badly, then he should have simply asked? Did he think that Mydei would refuse him if it were not a competition? How shallow did Phainon think he was?

For some reason, it pisses him off…!

“Phainon,” Mydei grunts, voice straining from the effort. The Deliverer gasps. “Give in to me…!”

“You said my name?” Phainon asks, dazed. For a split second, his hand goes slack.

It's enough.

Mydei *slams* Phainon's hand down onto the table with all of his might and *roars.* The crowd answers his call with a matching bellow, the noise sending vibrations through the floor.

He and the Deliverer lock eyes. Phainon doesn't even look disappointed. Just– Awed.

“THE WINNER IS PRINCE MYDEIMOOOOOS!” The orator booms. The crowd erupts with noise normally reserved for their more legitimate fighting tournaments. Arms lift to the skies, money changes hands, and Mydei is immediately surrounded by his people, who act like he's won the finals instead of just the semis.

He chances a glance back at Phainon, and–

Do you even know what kind of face you're making, Deliverer? Mydei thinks, helplessly. He crooks a finger and beckons Phainon over. *Don't look*

at me like that. Don't make that ridiculous expression.

As though pulled by an invisible thread, Phainon practically floats to him.

“I won,” Mydei says. For a second, Mydei thinks that he didn't even hear, on account of the crowd, but–

“You did,” Phainon says, transfixed by something that Mydei is too terrified to name. And then he blinks, and the moment is gone. “...But you're not the true winner. Castorice will avenge me!”

“...Right,” Mydei says. Overcome by some strange urge, the prince flicks Phainon's forehead.

“Wh– Hey!”

“We'll be having words about my win later, Deliverer,” he announces, and marches away before Phainon can even wonder about the use of his title.

Of course, Mydei's match against Castorice goes as expected.

He can only hold onto Castorice's hand for so long before he's forced to drop it. There are children in the crowd, and he wouldn't want them to see him perish. And besides, even without her touch, she truly was strong. Strong enough to hold him back just long enough to claim victory.

“THE WINNER IS… LADY CASTORICE!” The orator declares, from a safe distance. Castorice ducks her head, looking incredibly flustered by all of the attention and applause. She takes her prizes without looking at anyone. “BRAGGING RIGHTS… FOR ETERNITY!!!”

The crowd goes wild once again. Mydei's sure that the entirety of Okhema could have predicted her victory when they saw her, but they still go crazy. He supposes that they owe that to the amount of Kremnoans in the crowd. His people did love a good bout.

Speaking of bouts…

He locks eyes with Phainon and drags a thumb across his neck. Even from a distance, he can see that man gulp. Heh.

“So, I'm at your mercy now,” Phainon says, as they reunite. He's not quite looking at him, which makes Mydei frown.

“You're distracted,” Mydei points out. “Are you truly bothered by your loss? You should have tried harder to win, then.”

“You cheated,” Phainon whines, though he'd never admit it was whining. “You never call me by name.”

“You shouldn't have been distracted by something so simple,” Mydei shakes his head.

“Not very honourable of you to take advantage of me like that, you know,” Phainon says, nudging him with an elbow.

“You were the one who wanted to take advantage of me,” Mydei says. “You could have simply asked to spend time with me, HKS. Now look at yourself. You're at my mercy, now.”

“That's– That's different,” Phainon babbles. “I thought you'd be entertained by the competition, you know? So it was a win-win, right?”

“Do I make you nervous, Deliverer?” Mydei teases, returning the man's previous words. “Was the idea of using your words so daunting?”

Phainon pouts like a child and turns away. A laugh escapes the prince's lips.

“Fine. I was entertained,” Mydei admits. He offers Phainon a hand. “Here.”

“...What are you doing?”

“I'm offering you my hand,” Mydei says, waving it around. “Didn't you say you'd hold it so I wouldn't run away?”

The Deliverer sucks in a breath. “But I lost,” he says, glancing between Mydei's hand and his face.

“You did,” Mydei says plainly. “In the most embarrassing way, might I add.”

“Hey–”

“That's why you'll be at my mercy for the rest of today,” Mydei continues. “And for the rest of your free days this month. To make sure you don't escape, I'll hold onto you. Hm?”

Though Mydei was forever at his people's service, he would admit to missing Phainon's company. It wasn't like Mydei didn't see his point– for some reason, it did feel as though the world was conspiring to keep them apart recently. If it wasn't missions, then it was worldly obligations. If it wasn't obligations, then it was unforeseen circumstances. It would be no hardship to reassure the man, and to reinforce their bond.

Phainon gapes at him. Before Mydei can wave his hand around impatiently, the Deliverer lunges at his hand and holds it like it'd disappear if he didn't grab it fast enough.

“Don't think that you've won,” Mydei says, “As part of your punishment, you'll be paying for dinner, of course.”

“Don't I always?”

Mydei allows the man to turn them around to start the familiar walk to Marmoreal Diner–

–and they nearly bump right into Castorice, who is standing right behind them. There's a look on her face that Mydei's never seen before, a dawning look of realization– but what she's realized is unknown to him.

“Lady Castorice? Are you feeling well?”

“Yes, why?”

“You're flushed,” Mydei explains, distracted from his tale. At his words, she turns an even deeper shade of pink, darker than her hair and clothes.

Castorice opens her mouth to say something, but closes it just as fast, like she's debating whether or not to say anything at all. Mydei watches her squeeze her eyes shut.

“Lord Mydei, if you only stopped to think about what you say, and where you are, you would understand…! Good day.”

He watches her scurry off, hands to her cheeks. “Is she well?” Mydei asks, turning to Phainon for answers.

Phainon isn't looking at him, nor is he gazing after Castorice. In fact, he's not looking at anything at all– his eyes are squeezed shut and his face is bright red.

“Are *you* well?” Mydei demands, alarmed.

“Let's just go,” Phainon blurts, and practically breaks into a run.

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“...So yes, I had long believed that the two of you had shared a passionate encounter on that day,” Castorice says, to uproarious applause. “How could anyone possibly mistake that situation for a platonic bond? I, for one, did not.”

“How can you even recall what he and I said to one another?” Mydei demands, attempting to will his blush away.

“You have these conversations in public,” Castorice reminds him gently. “Everyone in the general area can hear you.”

“It makes for great entertainment!” Tribbie cheers. Wow. Thank you, Lady Tribbie. Couldn't someone help him out here?

He looks to the Deliverer. This would be a wonderful time for Phainon to miraculously wake up, so of course that doesn't happen. Mydei has the sudden urge to pinch his nose shut to see if that will wake him. It takes all of his willpower, but he resists the temptation. HKS. See what he endures for this man?

He looks to the rest of the crowd. Unsurprisingly, everyone else avoids his gaze. Everyone but Caelus, who is eating little cakes. Like he's watching a performance. Where the hell did he even get those?

“Why are you looking at me? Don't tell me that you want *more* proof?” Caelus asks, rubbing the back of his head. Crumbs fly everywhere. “This is going way past denial territory, this is like actual major tsundere behaviour in the wild. I didn't think that you guys really existed irl.”

The prince scrunches up his face at the unfamiliar word. “What is a tsundere?” Mydei asks, wondering if he should be insulted right now.

Caelus sucks in a huge breath– and then exhales just as fast. “Oh, you. You almost got me there! Trying to distract me, huh? And you would have gotten away with it too, if it weren't for my meddling self!”

Mydei looks to Dan Heng, who just shakes his head. Alright then. A question for a later time.

“If we're talking Myphai slash Phaidei moments– before you ask, that's your names combined into a ship name, and before you ask again, I'll tell you what a ship is later–” Incredible that Caelus managed to figure out what Mydei wanted to ask before he even managed to get the words out. “–the obvious one that no one's brought up yet is that beauty contest from, like, literally a week ago! The Top Ten Most Beautiful Faces in Amphoreus Competition! Come on, it's right there!”

Mydei shuts his eyes like that would quiet the eager chatter of the crowd. Yes, *that* competition. He's been trying so hard to forget it– nevermind that the events took place so recently that he still laid awake at night thinking about them!

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Apparently, it starts with a brawl in a tavern. The specifics weren't known to Mydei, as he had better things to do than to keep an ear to the ground for drunken remarks, but all he knew was that blood was spilled over what seemed like a harmless question–

Who is the most beautiful of the Chrysos Heirs?

Hardly something to fight over, if you ask Mydei. But no one asks him. In fact, the general populace is presumably trying to keep this question away from the Heirs– as though they could keep anything from Aglaea– and they're all failing at it. No one can keep a secret in this city, thanks to the Verax Leos and the general love of gossip that all Okhemans seem to possess.

The majority of the Chrysos Heirs are content to pretend like they haven't heard. Phainon finds it hilarious, because of course he does. Mydei's certain that Cipher is hedging her bets and putting money down on some people's answers– but other than that, it doesn't really affect his daily life. Sure, he gains a bigger audience when he trains with his men, but it's not like the additional eyes hurt anyone, so he disregards them.

But then more people come. And then more. And even more just follow Mydei around from a distance. They think they're being subtle, but it's difficult when it feels as though *everyone* is staring at him.

It wasn't as though Mydei was unused to stares– he was the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos, the Son of Gorgo, one of the Chrysos Heirs. But it was getting ridiculous– why were people spying on him when he ate? Cooked? Breathed?

He wasn't the only one starting to be bothered by it all.

“I can't believe this is all because the citizens can't determine which of us is the “most beautiful,”” Phainon grumbles at mealtime, putting obvious quotation marks around the words. “Their staring is starting to hurt.”

He fakes a shudder to make the triplets giggle.

“...I agree,” Castorice says, pushing around the food on her plate. “The citizens are getting too close to me when I work… It's dangerous…”

“The professor has started brandishing his gun in class,” Hyacine confesses, hand cupped around her mouth. “This whole “beautiful” thing is really a

double-edged sword for him– for one, many more students show up to class. But unfortunately, they're not listening to him at all… “If you're not going to listen in class, I'll give you a reason to,” or so he says… It's a little scary.”

Aglaea makes an amused sound, drumming her fingers against the table. “Serves that man right. Though I must admit that I too have been quite bothered by how *preoccupied* the citizens have been with that silly question. It interferes with my work. I do hope that they find the answer to their question soon.”

The unspoken *this better be resolved soon*, ***or else*** in her words sends shivers down everyone's spines. Mydei meets eyes with Phainon and they both wince. How were they supposed to settle this?

Unlike the rest of the Heirs, the new additions to their table, Caelus and Dan Heng, don't hear the underlying threat in her words. Well, perhaps Dan Heng does hear it.

Caelus clearly does not.

“What's the issue,” Caelus asks, barely stopping to chew his food. “Can't this be resolved really fast?”

“How?” Phainon asks, genuinely curious. “We'd appreciate your help, Trailblazer.”

“Why not just hold an actual vote?” Caelus asks, eyes sparkling. “Settle it once and for all with a ballot or something?”

…Of course. How simple! Why hadn't any of them thought of this before? It was so obvious, Mydei is slightly embarrassed that the thought hadn't occurred to him first.

“But it wouldn't be fun if it was just the Heirs,” Caelus continues, practically glowing. Mydei and Phainon watch Dan Heng bury his head in his hands and exchange glances. “We should do it! A Top Ten Most

Beautiful Faces in Amphoreus Competition! We'll make the citizens rank everyone on paper, count ‘em all up, and bam! Problem solved!”

Caelus, Mydei finds, is like an incredibly cheerful boulder sent rolling down a hill. When he's set on an idea, he's set. Impossible to predict, difficult to contain, unthinkable to stop.

“That's a wonderful idea, Little Gray!” Tribbie cheers.

“Hehe, I know,” Caelus agrees, like he doesn't realize what he's inadvertently signed up for. “No need to thank me.”

Aglaea smiles at Caelus. “Yes, what a wonderful idea.”

“...I sense I've made a mistake of some kind,” Caelus says, finally being made aware that he's spilled blood in the water.

“You'll be in charge of it all, I presume,” Aglaea says, folding her hands together. “I'm counting on you to do your very best, Caelus. The peace of the Chrysos Heirs is at stake here.”

Mydei hears Caelus gulp and shakes his head. Aglaea's undivided attention was difficult to bear– he wasn't sure how that professor managed to stand it.

“...Fine! If I'm gonna do it, I'll do it well! Come on, Dan Heng!” Caelus cheers, dragging the poor man out of his seat and out of the room. His fluffy pink squirrel thing follows, just as eager.

“...They'll be fine, right?” Hyacine wonders aloud.

“They'll be fine!” Phainon reassures her, pumping a fist. “The Trailblazers are dependable people!”

“They have no choice but to be fine,” Aglaea says, with another smile. Was it just Mydei, or did the temperature drop just now? He shudders.

“If you're cold, you should really start wearing proper clothing,” Phainon simpers unnecessarily.

“Shut your mouth, Deliverer.”

A day passes, and– it really is going just fine! Better than fine, even. The staring has mostly slowed– people take one glance at him, giggle, and then move on, eager to peer into the faces of others. Apparently the citizens have only mere days to cast their votes, so everyone has been jumping from one location to another as quickly as they possibly can. The Chrysos Heirs’ peace seems to be close at hand.

Although… This competition did have some unforeseen side effects.

The people of Okhema are giggly.

There's no other word for it.

Endless streams of sweet nothings flood the streets, like Mnestia herself had personally put a spell on the citizens. Every moment of the day, Mydei hears words like *of course I'll vote for you! You're the most beautiful person in the world!* and *No Chrysos Heir could ever measure up to the way you make me feel* and so on and so forth.

Kósmima. Gem. *O kallistē mou.* My most beautiful. *Moro mou.* My baby.

All of these endearments are unfamiliar to Mydei. In the first place, the children of Castrum Kremnos have no word for romance, so– this whole commotion has almost nothing to do with him. Mydei pours himself a goblet of pomegranate juice and milk and takes to the rooftops for some true alone time–

–or so he thinks. Couples have already flooded their corners. In fact, all of the hiding places that Mydei can think of are all occupied by giggly couples, too lost in each other's eyes to even register Mydei's appearance. All Mydei can think to do is retreat to his quarters for some peace–

–though even that is short lived.

“You're a difficult man to track when there aren't crowds following you like bees to honey,” the Deliverer greets, appearing in his doorway. He didn't

even bother to knock, or to wait for Mydei to let him in. In fact, he closes the door behind him like he's received a handwritten invitation to stay awhile.

Anyone else would have been dealt with swiftly by now. Alas. He can forgive the man's blunders. Kephale knows Mydei's been allowing the man several liberties he would never give to others.

“Perhaps your tracking skills aren't up to par,” Mydei counters, setting down his drink. “Why wouldn't I be found in my quarters?”

“You're never here,” Phainon laughs. “Why would I bother to look? You barely even think of this room as yours. Look around, it's as empty as your head.”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “HKS. Be grateful that my goblet is full, or I would have thrown it at you.”

“You could try and settle down,” Phainon says, taking a seat in the chair across from him. “You've been here for how long and you haven't bothered to personalize the place at all? Why don't I help you pick out something from the market as a favour.”

“No,” Mydei says, immediately.

“An immediate rejection,” Phainon laments, throwing himself over the arm of his chair. “How will I ever go on?”

“I hear you have awful taste,” Mydei scowls. “You're not to be in charge of anything aesthetics-wise. Ever.”

“I'll have you know that my taste is excellent! I like what I like, and I won't let anyone sway me!” Phainon says, shooting up from his slump. “But speaking of taste…”

The Deliverer pats himself down and procures a sheet from seemingly thin air.

“The Trailblazer asked me to pass this to you,” Phainon says, handing Mydei the slip of paper. “Here. Your very own voting ballot.”

“I don't need that,” Mydei says, with a frown.

“Come now, Mydeimos,” Phainon drawls. “It's all part of the democratic process. How can we be sure of who's most beautiful if we don't count everyone's votes?”

“I'm not even an Okheman citizen,” Mydei says, unwilling to involve himself in this.

“Ah, but that's not important. It says right at the top; “Top Ten Most Beautiful Faces in Amphoreus,” see? It doesn't specify Okhema. And why would that matter? Your own people have been voting. I've already voted, and I'm not from Okhema either.”

The prince raises his brows. “You've already voted?”

“The Trailblazer put a lot of effort into this after all,” Phainon says, smiling brightly. Mydei can hardly look at him. “And besides, isn't this fun? Normally our city-wide votes are for formal, unfun things. We should hold votes like this every so often.”

Mydei sighs and reads over the ballot. At the top, it reads **Top Ten Most Beautiful Faces in Amphoreus Competition** and below that is an empty, numbered list from one to ten. *Please fill in who you think is most beautiful here!*

“Pretty simple, right?” Phainon says. “Unless… My speculation was correct and you can't read or write?!”

Mydei leans over to smack Phainon on the arm.

“Ow! Hey!”

In retaliation, Phainon snatches the goblet off the side table and takes a sip.

“HKS,” Mydei scowls. “Get your own drink, you thief.” He tries to take it away, but Phainon holds the drink behind him and sticks out his tongue. Childish.

“Yours is the only one here, and I'm thirsty,” Phainon replies, like that's a reasonable defense for stealing Mydei's juice. “And no one else but you can get the ratio for this right.”

“Am I supposed to be flattered? You stole my drink! Have you decided to worship Zagreus in the time I haven't seen you?”

“Just hurry up and fill out the form,” Phainon says, handing Mydei a pen.

“Do not command me,” Mydei huffs, though he does take it. “What a ridiculous…”

Immediately, Mydei is stumped. Who, indeed, *did* possess the most beautiful face in all of Amphoreus?

“...I can teach you to write,” the Deliverer offers, hovering over Mydei's shoulder now. Without looking, the prince reaches up to yank at Phainon's cheek. “OW! I'm trying to be nice here!”

“I'm being nice by not throwing you out on your ass,” Mydei spits. “Why don't you go and do something useful?”

“I am being useful,” Phainon denies. “As soon as you're done, I'm meant to be handing your ballot to the Trailblazer.”

“Right. And you're not curious about who I think is most beautiful?”

“How could I not be?” Huh. Mydei didn't expect him to admit it. “Our brutish crown prince who doesn't even know how to decorate a room– who could he possibly find aesthetically pleasing? Perhaps his precious dromas, Kokopo?”

Mydei scowls up at the Deliverer, who's– closer than he expected. At this distance, Mydei can count his every eyelash. “Use his full title.”

“Why, of course, your Highness,” Phainon begins, playfully. “Your dromas, The Fierce Beast of Kremnos: Kokopo III. How dare I besmirch his name?”

“As long as you understand,” Mydei huffs, still staring up at Phainon, who's smiling wide. Hmm. Hmmmmmm. Now that he's thinking about it, the list wasn't so difficult to fill out after all.

Mydei puts pen to paper and writes out a name.

“Don't tell me you're actually writing down your dromas’ na–”

The Deliverer’s voice cracks and cuts off on the last word.

“What's wrong with you now, Deliverer?” Mydei asks. He then has the great pleasure of watching Phainon turn from pale to pink to a vivid shade of red. “Do you disagree with my choice?”

“*M-me?!*” The Deliverer shrieks, pointing at his own name. His hand is shaking.

“Don't act surprised,” Mydei says. “Look at yourself in the mirror. Is there anyone else that can rival you?”

“But I– but you– Wh– Mydei?!”

Mydei winces at the sudden increase in volume. “Are you well? Quit yelling, I can hear you perfectly fine.”

Phainon's not looking at him. “You're making fun of me!” He accuses. “You– you're so– ARGH! I can't believe that you think *I'm* the most beautiful in all of Amphoreus when– when you– URGHHH!”

Was he getting angry?

“Why wouldn't I think that you are the most beautiful person in all of Amphoreus?” Mydei asks, genuinely confused.

“Well– I just– What about your pride?!” Phainon demands, slamming a hand down on the table.

“What does that have to do with anything? I'm merely stating the facts.”

For some reason, it looks as though steam is leaving Phainon's ears. “I– I don't understand!”

“You possess a visage that would compel men to wage wars in your name,” Mydei explains, nodding to himself. “Your smile is uniquely captivating– I do believe that you could lure sailors to their demise with a single grin.”

When Phainon speaks again, his voice is hoarse. “...I thought the tale was about how it was beautiful singing that bewitched men to fall into the sea, and not beautiful faces.”

Mydei hums. “Yes. Your face is more spellbinding than any song.”

“You–!”

The more that Mydei thinks about it, the more he's sure that he's correct. “I have yet to meet anyone as lovely as you,” he says. “Your face, your presence, your body… In my eyes, there is no one that can match your might. Take pride in your features, Deliverer– In this domain, at least, you reign supreme.”

Phainon collapses back into his chair, hand covering his face. He's muttering something to himself. Something like *why is he so…* and like *must I truly hold myself back when he's…* Very strange, this man.

“You better brace yourself, Mydeimos,” Phainon threatens. Though it's less of a threat and more of a statement.

The prince snorts.

“Only you would find fault with being called beautiful. Speaking of which, who did you vote for?” Mydei asks, moving onto number two. That was easy. Lady Aglaea was uniquely beautiful. He writes her name down with little to no hesitation.

“I'm not telling you,” Phainon huffs. He reaches out and downs the rest of Mydei's drink. Fine, if that made him feel better.

“How childish.”

“Oh yeah?”

Before Mydei can even blink, Phainon snatches the page away and leaps to his feet. “I'm leaving! You can just hide away in your empty room! Why don't you go ahead and look in the mirror like you told me to– Maybe you'll understand how I feel then!”

“You thief!” Mydei yells, as the Deliverer sprints away. “You actually are a child! What does my mirror have to do with– Get back here, HKS!”

Mydei doesn't manage to catch up to the Deliverer. In fact, he doesn't even get to catch a glimpse of that man for a day– he doesn't show up for their shared meal, and he doesn't show up for training. Before Mydei can go and drag Phainon out of whatever hole he's hidden himself in by the collar, he's asked by Aglaea to help the Trailblazer count the ballots.

“Originally, Phainon had offered to help out,” Aglaea begins, smile sharp. “But he's been distracted. In fact, he's gone and ran away– *Phainon*, whom I believed lacked shame. Mydeimos. You wouldn't happen to know why the Deliverer is acting this way, hmm?”

Because Mydei is not stupid, he says nothing.

“I thought so,” Aglaea continues. “Thank you for volunteering to help the Trailblazer in his place.”

So Mydei goes to help the Trailblazer because no one says no to Aglaea.

“I don't wannaaaaa do paperwooork,” Caelus complains, as a greeting. Mydei takes a seat at the table across from him. “I wasn't built for paperwooork. I was built to hit things with a bat and to go ‘sploooooring…”

Caelus is surrounded by piles and piles of ballots, stacked so tall and so precariously that Mydei is wary about breathing near them. The prince is genuinely surprised that this many people live in Okhema– or perhaps there are people submitting multiple ballots?

“You're not the only one tallying the votes,” Dan Heng says, unimpressed. Mydei notes that he too, is surrounded by stacks of paper. In fact, he didn't even see the man until he spoke, even though he was sitting right next to Caelus– the only part of Dan Heng that he sees is the very top of his head, like some fluffy, dark beacon. “I'm here too. And Lady Aglaea sent us a few of her Garmentmakers to help count. They're faster than both of us combined. Chin up. It'll be over soon.”

“Memememe,” adds the pink squirrel, who was also here. Okay, was Caelus simply pretending to understand her, or was Mydei out of the loop here?

“Yeah, you're right, Dan Heng, Mem. The faster I work, the faster I can go out! Thanks for joining us, Mydei. Is Phainon coming soon?”

“The Deliverer has fled, like a coward,” Mydei says, taking a stack of ballots and counting their votes. “I have no idea where that fool is.”

“Lucky,” Caelus complains, slumping over in his chair. Dan Heng clears his throat and the Trailblazer fixes his posture. “Yeah, I got it, I'm on it.”

The votes are heavily skewed in favour of the Chrysos Heirs, of course. Aglaea is dominating nearly every single ballot, and as expected, Phainon isn't too far behind. Votes for Hyacine, votes for Castorice, votes for Cifera, votes for Anaxagoras… Every ballot usually has most, if not all of the Heirs’ names written down, just in different orders.

Mydei's own name does show up quite frequently… He huffs.

“You're quite popular, Mydei,” Caelus comments. “Nice.”

“My people are biased,” Mydei acknowledges, shaking his head. “Their votes are out of loyalty, I presume.”

“Actually, it wasn't just them who voted,” Caelus explains, waving ballots around. “I mean, look at the haul we've got! Can't be just them. Besides, look at you. You've got that princely, royal-y glow.”

“Thank you?”

“You're on my list,” Caelus informs him, with a thumbs up. “All of the Heirs are! You all look like the kind of beautiful that people would whale on in gacha games.”

Mydei looks to Dan Heng. “It's a compliment,” the other Trailblazer confirms, voice flat.

“I tried to vote for Dan Heng too,” Caelus says with a sigh. “Because he would definitely put up a fight in any beautiful face competition, yeah? But he said that he shouldn't even qualify because we're not even from–”

Dan Heng covers Caelus’ mouth with his hand. “I'm also embarrassed,” Dan Heng explains, glaring at the other Trailblazer. “The most important thing here is that I'm embarrassed, so stop.”

Mydei can surmise a guess as to what exactly was about to leave Caelus’ lips, but all he can do is nod. Everyone has their secrets.

“But look at you,” Caelus whines. It comes out like *bughg loof achoo.*

Truly, Mydei is impressed. It's not everyday that he tends to feel like– ah, how would Phainon put it? A third wheel? Normally he only feels this way when professor Anaxagoras deigns to join them for meals and he and Aglaea spend the whole meal bickering.

“Stop,” Dan Heng says. Caelus stops. With a sigh, Dan Heng turns to Mydei– or at least he thinks that's what he does. Mydei still can't see him. “We got your ballot, by the way. Phainon dropped it off yesterday while also running away. Did you want to finish writing in names, or are you alright with just having written down two?”

“I am,” Mydei confirms. “The results of this vote don't particularly matter to me.”

“Alright,” Dan Heng says.

“...Though, while we're on the subject, is it possible to see the Deliverer’s ballot?” Mydei asks. “That man watched me fill in names but refused to tell

me who he personally voted for. …Or is that a breach of confidentiality?”

Dan Heng hums. “It's not like we're voting for anything that actually requires confidentiality. Here, I can dig it out. We put all of the Heirs’ ballots together– you wouldn't believe how many people tried to sneak a peek at them.”

Ha. Take that, Deliverer.

“Phainon's top ten list? I got it memorized, easy!” Caelus’ head shoots up, eager to share the information. “You don't need to worry–”

“Worry? Worry about what?” Mydei blurts. He's not worried about anything! Why would he worry? He's just curious, is all. He just wants to know what's going on in that frustrating head of his.

“–he just wrote your name ten times. Like, we get it, man! We know you think Mydei is beautiful! So do the rest of us!”

Mydei shuts up.

What was that?

“For the record, while Dan Heng is my number one, you're definitely fighting for number two with Aglaea,” Caelus continues, like he didn't just send Mydei's world spinning. “I would have written Dan Heng's name ten times too if he didn't tell me that was “cheating” and to “please stop,” and “give me that paper right now, Caelus!””

What?

“Here, look,” Dan Heng says, passing Phainon's ballot over the stacks. Mydei practically rips it out of his hand, and there, in familiar writing–

Mydeimos, the ballot reads, ten times in a row.

Mydei sinks into his chair.

“It's really cute,” Caelus nods. “You both think of each other as the most beautiful of all. He was definitely shy about handing this ballot in, like I almost burst out laughing at the look on his face– Ah, man. Does that mean we shouldn't have told you? Whoops.”

“As long as he keeps it a secret that we told him,” Dan Heng murmurs.

“You have my word,” Mydei replies, distracted.

So.

That's why Phainon hid his vote from him. Was he embarrassed to find Mydei attractive? Or was he embarrassed over the fact that their appreciation for one another was mutual? Whatever the reason, it was clear that from the way Phainon ran, it was Mydei's win.

There wasn't a competition, and yet the prince feels as though he's claimed victory regardless.

Mydei chuckles.

“Heh. What a fool,” the prince muses, unaware of the fond look on his face. There was no need to run. Ten votes? How embarrassing, Deliverer. Mydei would have to tease him about this later.

The Trailblazers exchange glances.

“...All idiot couples need to blow up,” Caelus mutters solemnly, Dan Heng nodding along in agreement. “There's gotta be a limit to how much fluff a guy is force fed…”

“What?” Mydei asks, not having heard a thing.

“Nothing! I was just saying that Aglaea's going to win anyway,” Caelus says, tearing through the ballots with ease. “I swear, ninety percent of the votes put her at number one. We should really just stop counting since we know the outcome.”

“Caelus.”

“I know…”

The three of them continue to tally the votes, the pink squirrel cheering them on in the background. Halfway through the ballots, Phainon bursts into the room, dripping in sweat. He's carrying something, though Mydei doesn't know what. It's covered with a sheet of some kind.

“Mydei!”

“Careful, HKS! You'll knock over our piles!” Mydei scolds, waving a fist around.

“Oh, sorry,” Phainon apologizes, wiping the sweat from his brow with the back of his hand. “And sorry I'm late, I was doing. Stuff. I'll help count now.”

Caelus makes a noise of agreement, too focused on the ballots in front of him to give the Deliverer a proper greeting. He's “locked in,” as he'd declared minutes ago.

Dan Heng gestures to the seat next to Mydei, which Phainon collapses into with a groan.

“What were you up to?” Mydei demands. “Aglaea was not happy with you.”

“I'll make it up to her,” Phainon says dismissively. “This was important.”

“Oh?” Mydei prompts, completely forgetting that he was determined to tease the Deliverer the moment that he saw him again.

“Yeah, I went hunting for antiques to find you a new bronze mirror, because yours clearly isn't working,” Phainon says, gesturing to the object he's set at his feet.

“What?” Mydei demands. He pulls the sheet off of the object, and true to the Deliverer’s word, it is indeed a bronze mirror. The prince doesn't have an eye for antiques, but even he can tell that this mirror is precious and

valuable beyond compare– its gleam striking in the light. “Are you serious? My mirror works fine, it's a mirror! Why did you do this?

“So you could see who has the most beautiful face in all of Amphoreus, obviously,” Phainon says, a tiny grin on his face.

“I don't–”

Mydei snaps his mouth shut as the words sink in. “...Deliverer, you are insufferable.”

“Hey now, I went out of my way to get you a nice gift and this is the thanks I get?”

The prince frowns. “This mirror won't change the fact that you are the most beautiful–”

“Quit flirting and lock in!” Caelus interrupts, an edge to his words. “I just wanna clock in and out! Think about my feelings here!”

“Flirting–?”

“This wasn't– well, it kind of is but–” What?

“LOCK IN!”

So they lock in.

To no one's surprise, Aglaea is the winner of the competition. She takes the announcement in stride and uses her new title to make everyone finally shut up.

In third place, Mydei isn't really affected by the results… Though, he does have a new piece of furniture to decorate with. Several new pieces, actually, considering the fact that the second place winner, Phainon, keeps dropping off new objects in his room like a cat does dead mice.

(If he spends more time than ever fussing over his appearance, that's between him and the mirror.)

.

“Oh man, Dan Heng and I had to listen to them flirt for like ever,” Caelus reminisces.

“It was not flirting!”

Tribbie puts a hand on Mydei's shoulder. “De, at this point you're just wrong.”

Their audience has grown even bigger, which– hooray. Mydei will tear Phainon a new one. Every person in this crowd will be one terrible meal that the man must choke down. Kephale, wouldn't someone help him out here?

Ah.

Was that Krateros in the crowd? Mydei shoots his mentor a pleading look, which he ignores. Unfortunately for him, Mydei's past the point of shame, and is now determined to drag anyone down with him so long as he doesn't suffer this humiliation alone. “Teacher! Is the Deliverer in– in l-love with me?!”

Someone had to have some sense in this crowd, right?

“Of course he is, you fool! Why are you still in denial?! Kiss that man awake and end this charade! How much longer will we be subject to this torture?”

Mydei reels back like he's been slapped. His teacher, acknowledging the Deliverer? Acknowledging some– some sort of feelings that the man possessed for him?

“I thought that you didn't approve of him,” Mydei says, voice weak.

“This and that are two separate things! Of course I don't approve! He has yet to prove his worth to me as your suitor!” Krateros snaps. “In the Queen's stead, only I can approve any and all of your courtships– and the

Deliverer has yet to plead his case to me, though he insists on following you around like some lost chimera regardless! It's improper!”

Mydei is speechless. “The Deliverer isn't aware of Kremnoan courtship customs,” Mydei says, when he finally finds his words. “No one is expecting him to be.”

“*All of your people are expecting him to be,*” Krateros corrects. “It is the very least you deserve, as befitting your station.”

“But he's not–”

“You deserve a proper courtship,” his mentor continues, shaking his head. “One that follows Kremnoan customs. Not whatever mess he's attempting to blunder through with you. How ridiculous. You are of royal blood. How could some ordinary man be worthy…”

“The Deliverer *is* worthy!” Mydei immediately snaps back, wincing when he notices the growing smiles on their audiences’ faces. “I– I only mean–”

“Bah! I know what you mean. I have watched you grow from a youth to a young man, Mydeimos, and know your heart well. You are only in denial for that fool's sake.” Krateros huffs. “At the very least, *you* are aware of your station, my prince.”

Mydei looks down at Phainon, who is still slumbering away.

“Aw, De. Is that why you're in denial?” Tribbie asks. All three of the triplets begin to pat him on the back.

“...I can't even begin to hope for a life beyond my duties,” is all the prince says in reply. Urgh, now he's getting sympathetic looks. He didn't say any of that to be pitied– Mydei only wanted the rest of them to understand.

“I didn't teach you to be a fool,” his mentor replies, shaking his head. “Don't get me involved any further in this mess. And tell that fool when he wakes up to come and face me!”

Krateros flees, like Thanatos himself is chasing him. If it were anyone else, Mydei would call them a coward. Alas.

“Is Phainon still asleep?”

The crowd parts to let two familiar faces through– Aglaea and Anaxagoras, who are– elegantly, of course– pretending like they aren't attempting to elbow each other out of the way.

“Agy!” Trianne greets, tugging at her clothes. “Yep! We're trying to make De see reason!”

“You still have yet to kiss him, Mydeimos?” Aglaea observes, her tone cool and unimpressed. Mydei can tell– even though he's not looking at her at all– she's raised a single, judgmental eyebrow at him.

“Are you perhaps afraid? Whatever for?”

Ah, cutting right to the quick. Always as sharp as her shears. Well, at this point, Mydei had no dignity left to lose.

“What if it's actually not me?” Mydei wonders aloud, overcome by weakness. He also wonders if he sounds as pathetic as he feels.

“Then True Love's Kiss was not actually the solution, and we must go searching for another,” Aglaea replies, matter of fact.

“I think the obvious conclusion would be that I wasn't actually his True Love,” he tries. It's a weak reply. Mydei can admit this, at least.

“But there is no other option for him than you,” Aglaea counters. Her voice is sure. Clinical, even, like she's stating undeniable facts. The sky is blue. Change is inevitable. Mydei is Phainon's one True Love. “Phainon has been, and will always be, a selfless man. However, he is uniquely greedy when it comes to you.”

Mydei doesn't reply.

“Do you recall when Phainon brought you and your people back to Okhema?” Aglaea asks. “That was the very first time he had defied one of my orders. Since I was unaware of your true importance, I had seen you as a threat and had asked him to… Well. You are an intelligent man. I'm sure you understand my reasoning.”

It's not an apology, and Mydei didn't expect one. In fact, he respects her even more for acknowledging how they had come to know one another.

“For the very first time, Phainon had asked something of me,” Aglaea says, voice cool. “Begged, really. He wanted you safe. Hale and whole. A funny thing to demand when you had only just met. Your encounter had moved him in a way no else could, Mydeimos.”

All Mydei can do is nod his head.

“You have his loyalty. You have his trust. Is it truly so odd to think that you have his heart as well?”

The prince sighs.

“...Not so odd,” he admits.

Their audience actually starts to applaud. Mydei glares at them, and they all collectively find other things to stare at.

“He deserves someone that has more time,” Mydei says, quietly.

“Deserves?” Anaxa repeats. “I think he deserves to choose his one True Love for himself.”

The prince scowls, but can't find a rebuttal.

“It's embarrassing,” Anaxa adds, a thinly veiled expression of disgust on his face. “He *pines,* like the besotted fool that he apparently is. How anyone is unable to see it is beyond me.”

He gives Mydei a pointed look that the prince chooses to ignore. For his own sake.

“How do you know that the Deliverer pines?” Mydei asks instead.

“Because he came to me, his professor, in search of advice,” Anaxa says. Uh oh.

“Like, what? Love advice?” Caelus asks, because he has no filter.

Anaxa nods. “Yes. I was married, after all.”

…

Past tense, married…

Mydei feels as though he shouldn't have heard that. Apparently the rest of their audience agrees, because a hush falls onto the crowd.

“Oh, really?” Caelus asks, utterly unaware. “Cool. To who?”

Impossibly, the crowd falls even more silent.

Hyacine grabs onto Mydei's arm. “Mydei, just kiss him already!!!”

“Come on De, smooching time!”

“...Don't be embarrassed…”

Alright, so Mydei was to be the sacrificial lamb. Understood. Anything to stop this conversation. Anything at all, even– even kissing the Deliverer!

He can do this. He's not hesitating. A Kremnoan would never hesitate.

The prince kneels at Phainon's side, and then decides that's an awkward angle to kiss him at, so he stands back up. Mydei supposes that he could just lean down, so he braces a hand next to Phainon's face and leans down…

Closer, closer…

Mydei shuts his eyes.

The snap of a camera disrupts his focus and he flinches away.

“Caelus!” Mydei hears Dan Heng snap. Of course.

The prince whirls around to see literally everyone leaning in to watch. Castorice even lifts a hand to wave. Well.

“...I can't kiss the Deliverer if you're watching,” Mydei tries. He is not stalling.

“Oh,” says Castorice. She crouches down and dutifully shields the eyes of Lady Tribbie and Lady Trinnon.

“Hey!” Tribbie protests. “I wanna see! I've got money riding on this!”

Mydei thinks that he needs a drink. One that Phainon will pay for, in full. And then another, and then another. Of course, the Deliverer would pay for those, too. He'd pay for this *entire day.*

No matter! Mydeimos was not scared! There was no word for scared in the Kremnoan dictionary!

It was only a kiss.

It was…

How long did Mydei have to kiss him for? Could he just kiss him on the cheek? Did their lips even have to touch? Was this a timed event?

He knows full well that he was overthinking it. That, deep down, he was only afraid that their relationship would change. Theirs was a bond between equals, nevermind their circumstances, nevermind their birthrights…

Was it truly so bad to take that step forward? To take Phainon's hand in this life, and not wait for the next one?

Mydeimos, Son of Gorgo, had never been known to falter. And he would not ever falter– not here, not now. If Phainon did not awaken with his kiss,

he'd scour the world to find who could. It would not change the Deliverer’s importance in his life, nor change the way that he made Mydei feel…

If Mydei woke Phainon up with a kiss, then wasn't it his win? He chuckles to himself.

“Wake now, Phainon,” Mydei commands. “I've kept you waiting long enough.”

With those words, Mydei leans down and kisses Phainon on the lips. It's short. Gentle. The prince pulls away ever so slightly, just to see if Phainon would wake immediately–

–and as if on cue, the Deliverer’s eyelids flutter open. The crowd, which had previously seemed to fall away, erupts with cheers.

“Mydei,” Phainon breathes, near-reverent.

“Phainon,” Mydei replies, just as breathless.

“My hero,” the Deliverer laughs, and then curls a hand around the back of Mydei's neck to drag him into another kiss.

It's wonderful. “You spent too much time asleep,” Mydei scolds, against his lips. “What do you have to say for yourself?”

Another kiss. Mydei could get used to this.

“...I had a dream that you punched me in the face,” Phainon mumbles, against Mydei's lips. “It was incredible.”

The prince grins. “Is that really all that you wish to say to your one True Love?” Prepare yourself, Phainon. Mydei would never let this go.

“What I really wanted to say is that it's my win,” Phainon murmurs.

…What did he just say?

“Excuse me?!” Mydei demands, shoving the man away. “You were foolish enough to need True Love's kiss to wake up from a trap– that you could have avoided easily– if you used your brain! It's my win. You were the one who needed me.”

“I'll always need you,” Phainon says. He says it so simply that Mydei feels heat rise to his face. With a groan, the Deliverer sits up on the daybed. “But it's still my win.”

“HKS. Incorrect,” Mydei scowls, folding his arms. He refuses to back down on this.

“The thing about True Love's kiss is that it needs to be mutual to work,” Phainon explains, eyes half-lidded. “So yeah, I win. You liiiiike me.”

Mydei huffs. “Of course I like you. I *love* you. Isn't that the point of True Love's kiss?” The words come naturally now that he's assured that it's mutual. He wouldn't falter with his feelings ever again.

Phainon's face immediately flushes. “Well– I– That's not fair, Mydeimos! I thought I had finally won against you in this, and you just– You can't just say it!”

“You should know by now that you won't claim victory over me that easily,” Mydei smirks.

“Well! I love you too!” Phainon yells. “I love you more, beat that!”

“Yeah? Prove it! Unless you're a coward?!”

“I'm no coward, Mydeimos!”

(“...They've completely forgotten that we're still here, haven't they?” Anaxa mutters, watching the idiot couple bicker and gaze into each other's eyes like they're the only people that exist.

“Let them have this. It's much better than watching them mope and pine,” Aglaea lifts a hand. “As promised, you must pay up. I'm never wrong about matters of the heart. You should have known better than to bet against me.”

Reluctantly, Anaxa hands over his pocketbook– and then falters. “You– You didn't plan this, did you?”

“Whatever do you mean? I am simply carrying out my duties as the one who bears the Coreflame of Romance.”

“Madwoman.”

“You flatter me.”)

End Notes

you know im still not sure why i decided to make mydei the narrator when i was planning this fic out i literally went wow mydei is so not the kind of character that i usually make my pov character. so why did i do that. idk probably cause i love him sososo much and i won his 50/50 and his lc. watch out phainon he loves me

i was also incredibly lucky for cas banner she also loves me but im too scared to roll for her lc cause i want anaxa and i have nothing lmao and am on a 50/50. may he be kind to everyone who wants him and good luck to everyone still pulling for cas. god anaxa better be kind to me i need to save for phainon still omglkgfdhkjg they hate us bad its back to back new characters lmfao

i hope you enjoyed sfdkfh. im also writing a flame reaver fic but who the fuck knows when thatll release if ever. im telling you so you can hold me to it. waaaaaaaaaah this phaidei shit is so serious og my god whats up with me.

thank you for reading

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